

Secure Access Content Design Guidelines

This document standardizes common content design elements for Secure Access. Standards are necessary so that each Secure Access UX designer and content doesn't have to "start from zero" when creating or updating various features and controls. A lack of standardization leads to a proliferation of inconsistent designs.

Note: This is a "living" document and is by no means perfect or complete. We are constantly revising it in an attempt to improve its content and, by extension, Secure Access. When using this guide, remember the following rule and you'll be fine: rules are meant to be broken, but you first have to know 'em before you can break 'em.

Cheers and don't forget to have fun.

Rule Number One

Write in the present tense and in an active voice.

Follow the core tenets of minimalist writing. Everything must be oriented towards the goal of users completing tasks. Only include as much information as needed to complete the task. And no more. Of course, space restrictions when writing UI text helps in not being able to ramble on too much.

Answer the questions "what" and "why", but not "how". Send users to Help for the answer to the question "how". "How" is answered by procedures.

Don't just "dump the docs" in the UI or build the Help system or docs in the UI.

A Help link is considered part of the information provided to Users to complete the task.

Other Rules to Live By

- Form is never more than an extension of content
- No ideas but in things
- When in doubt, follow the standards as set in the [Cisco Technical Content Style Guide](#)
- Do whatever Claws says

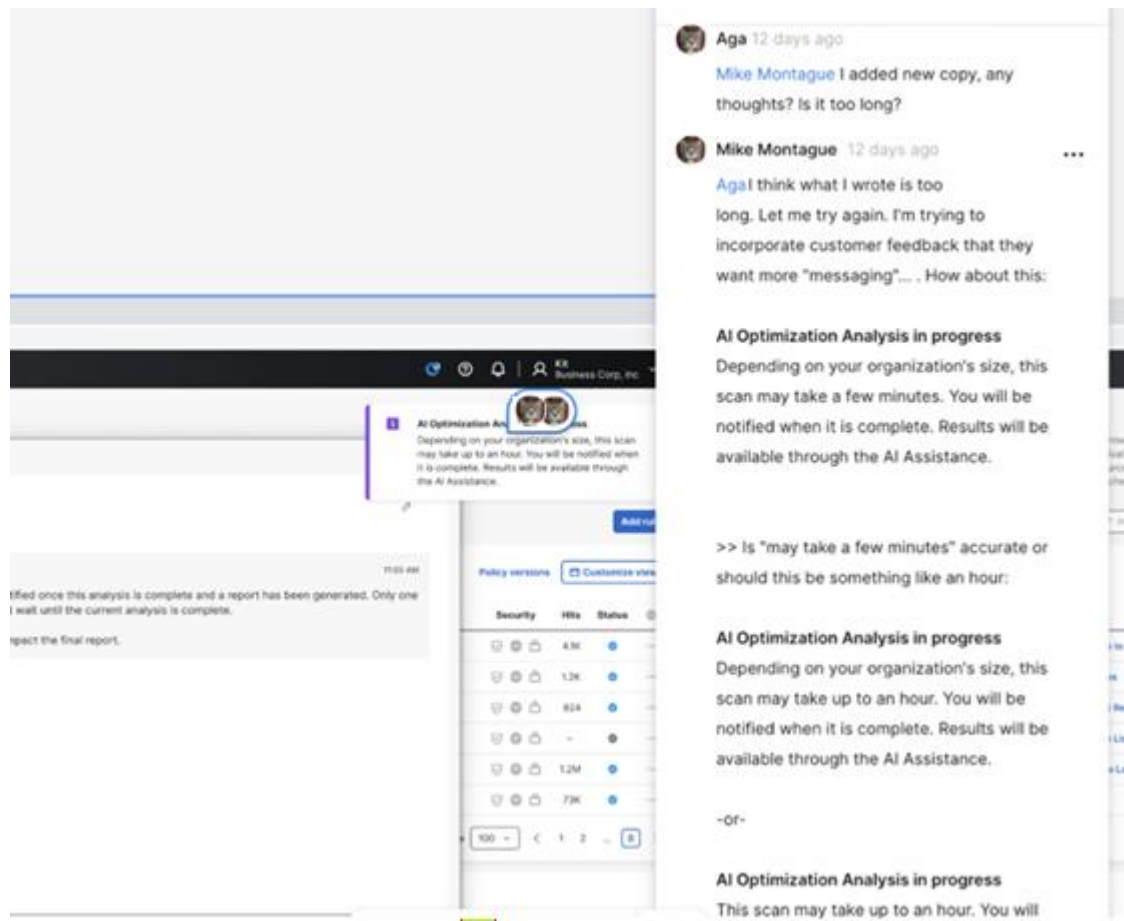
Working in Mocks – Figma

We do not update mocks directly; rather, we add comments with suggested UI text updates adjacent to the place in the mock where the updates need to be made. Suggestions can—and often do—include design updates to better accommodate information. These can be as small as suggesting a checkbox instead of a toggle, or as significant as suggesting a redesign of an entire section to better accommodate the information that the user needs to complete a task or tasks.

It is the UX designer's role to take our suggestions, update their mocks, and then (in a perfect

world) present the updates at the next handshake meeting. If further changes are needed, additional updates can be made, including new comments.

When adding your suggested text, always preface your entry by “tagging” the designer of the mock so that they receive an email notification about your comment. Generally, it is also helpful to add a note of introduction to the comment, providing any necessary explanation for your suggestion. It can also be beneficial to offer the UX designer alternative options, as sometimes the best text may be too long, or the subtleties of language allow for multiple ways to express something. Comments are also referenced by Engineering when working through UI tasks.



Helper Text

Helper Text is the introductory text that helps a user understand a page, section, or aspect of a feature. It is not marketing material used to sell a feature—meaning it is not “copy”.

Helper Text answers the following questions:

- What?
- Why?

Helper Text does not answer the following question:

- **How**
How is answered through the Help link connected to the Helper text.

Helper text is the first step toward helping users complete tasks.

Helper text must be displayed at the top of each page. This helper text must define and describe the page so that new users understand what and why it (the page not the text) exists. Experienced users use this text to get a quick reminder and refresh of why it exists. It may have been some time since a user was last on the page. Helper Text is also used to drive the user to the Help system. This Helper Text is not a replacement for Help.

Length

Helper text is always as short as possible. Aim for two lines for Helper text at top of page (approximately, 200 characters including spaces) and one line for Helper text (approximately, 100 characters including spaces) within cards and steppers etc. If this Helper text is longer than this suggested limit, consider revising. Remember that the purpose of this text is to help a user start to understand what and why and drive the User to Help rather than calling Support. It is not meant to guide the user on how to do something. Labels and such should be no more than about 25 characters long.

Help Links

Helper Text does not answer the question “How”. How is answered by providing a link at the end of the text to Help. The Help link does not include an introductory clause. So, the link to help in Helper text should always be: **Help**

Do not use phrases such as “Learn more”, or “For more information”. These are documentation paradigms and are not appropriate for the UI. Help is a heuristic cue meant to drive users to online help. Its goal is to get users to help themselves so that they do not contact support.

Help link is always placed at the end of the section of Helper text, and it is always on the same line as the end of the Helper text. Users scan rather than read. Always be thinking about a page’s legibility. Help link is always at the end of the Helper text section. NEVER embed Help links (or any type of link) within sentences, paragraphs, or sections. Always place links at the end of a section. Links are then easier to scan for.

Only use one Help link per section. One Help link at the top of each page and only one Help link per card. Help links can be added to the top of a drawer or modal when necessary. The key is to keep Help links to a minimum. In most cases, two per page is sufficient. Don't overuse Help links. If you find yourself in a situation where multiple Help links are being asked for a page, it is generally because there are design problems with the page. Reevaluate the page’s content, including headings, labels, etc.

Think of **Help** as a button and “Help” is the label of this button. Don’t think of Help as an x-ref as you might when writing documentation. This Help is part of the GUI. This will become an even more important concept over the next couple of years as the new docs portal